DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

When Is There No Blessing on a Misvah?

Derech Hashem 4:9:2-4

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 9, paragraphs 2-4 (the end of the book), with an introduction to Maamar Halkarim **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 16 May 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: lifting up ordinary life

The last chapter of Derech Hashem deals with the four kinds of misvot that fill a lifetime: constant, daily, seasonal and circumstantial. The class is now on the circumstantial ones, and the Rabbi explained why God gave them: to elevate our mundane life. You build a house, and there is a misvah to build a railing on the roof. You wear clothes, and there is a misvah not to mix wool and linen and to put sisit on a four-cornered garment. You own a vineyard, and there are laws about it. We live in a physical world that can easily pull us down, so these misvot keep turning the ordinary into something higher.

The same idea lies behind berakhot. The root of every blessing is Birkat HaMazon, the one blessing written in the Torah: you eat, you are satisfied, and you bless God for the land He has given you. By blessing God for the physical world, a person lifts that world up. From this the Rabbis learned to bless God after every enjoyment, and also over natural wonders such as thunder, lightning, the sea and the rainbow, so that a physical experience becomes a recognition of God's greatness.

Blessings before we eat (paragraph 3)

The Rabbi pointed out that the main blessing was originally the one after eating. "Unfortunately today many people say blessings before, but don't say blessings after." The Rabbis then added blessings before eating as well, to strengthen the same idea.

He stressed that this is not about denying pleasure. "You should enjoy your food. Taste it, be happy with it. No one is telling you to eat food you don't like." But we are not eating only for the sake of eating. We eat to look after the body so that we can study, pray, do misvot and help other people. When a person mentions God's name before enjoying something, remembering that this goodness comes from Him, the act of eating becomes a completely good act. The person and the world around him are elevated, instead of being sucked down into the mundane.

Blessings on misvot (paragraph 4)

The group listed the kinds of berakhot covered so far: after food, before food, and on natural wonders. Prayer is a separate category altogether. What is left is birkat hamisvot, the blessing over a misvah.

This cannot be a blessing of enjoyment, because, as the Gemara teaches, misvot were not given for our benefit. Instead, says the Ramhal, the Rabbis instituted these blessings to show our love and eagerness for the misvah and to thank God for favouring us with these opportunities for rectification. Through the blessing the action of the misvah is raised even higher, and God responds in kind: "The more we awaken, the more we come close, the more we search out the Almighty, so will be the amount which we will receive from God."

With the final words, "fortunate is the one who trusts in God", the book is complete. The Rabbi summed up the four parts: Part 1 about God, Part 2 about how God relates to us, Part 3 about the human spirit and prophecy, and Part 4 about daily life and misvot. A participant asked when blessings entered Jewish life. The Rabbi answered that they were instituted by the Men of the Great Assembly, around 2,200 years ago, and that life in biblical times was very different from Jewish life today.

When do we not make a blessing on a misvah?

The Rabbi added a summary of the rules, which he said are neatly summarised in the sources. There are four categories:

1. **A misvah with no action.** For example, the Torah's misvah of releasing loans in the Shemitah year: you fulfil it by doing nothing. Negative commandments are never blessed for the same reason; they are passive.
2. **A misvah that is not fully in your control.** Sedakah, visiting the sick, comforting mourners and honouring parents all depend on someone else. The poor man may refuse, the sick person may not want a visit, and a parent can forgo the honour. "Anything which is dependent on someone else, you never say a berakhah on it."
3. **A misvah that comes about through a sin.** Returning a stolen object is a Torah misvah, but it only exists because of the theft. Nor was a blessing said on the court's executions in the time of the Sanhedrin, because God is saddened by them. The Rabbi explained that this is also why there is no blessing on a get: a divorce can be given for wrong reasons, such as leaving a wife only because one found someone "better", and no one can see into a person's heart.
4. **Separating what is not yours.** Gifts to the Kohen are considered already set aside and not your own property, so no blessing is made on separating them.

A participant suggested that a get has no blessing because the wife might not accept it. The Rabbi explained that this does not work, since halachically a get can be delivered in front of two witnesses without her cooperation. Asked about yibbum, he agreed that it depends on the other person's consent, like sedakah. The same is true of the misvah to have children. The blessing at a wedding, he noted, is not over the misvah of marrying but over the permission to share a life together.

Looking ahead: Maamar HaIkarim

Although the four parts are finished, the book ends with the Ramhal's short essays on fundamentals, Maamar HaIkarim. Much of it revises what the group has learned, put "very neatly and tightly", but some is new. The Rabbi listed the topics: God, the spiritual world, Torah, reward and punishment, Gan Eden and Gehinnom, providence, prophecy, redemption, miracles and the Oral Law.

He noted that the main book never once discussed Gan Eden, Mashiah or the resurrection of the dead. This shows how small a part they play in the grand scheme compared with the World to Come. "Gan Eden is just a waiting room." The essays would begin that Thursday.

Summary

- Circumstantial misvot and berakhot exist to elevate the physical world, so we enjoy it with the right intentions.
- The original blessing is after eating; the Rabbis added blessings before, so that eating becomes a good act.
- Blessings on misvot express love and eagerness for the misvah, and God responds to the measure of our awakening.
- No blessing is said on a passive misvah, one dependent on others, one that comes through a sin, or the separation of what already belongs to someone else.
- With Derech Hashem complete, the class moves on to the ten essays of Maamar HaIkarim.

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